CONNECT DAILY

Monday 12 October 2026
themapsproject.com

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear "so what for your school" line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, get in touch.

TOP LINE

- A quiet two days since Thursday's briefing - no major new policy, inspection or funding story broke over the weekend.
- The one genuine development: Ofsted published interim findings from an independent evaluation of its own new-look inspection framework on Friday, broadly positive but flagging workload as still unresolved.
- Nothing new locally in Sheffield or South Yorkshire in the last 48 hours - today's diary items below are the main things on leaders' radar this fortnight.

DATES FOR THE DIARY

16 Oct 2026 — Midday deadline for Sheffield secondary school applications for September 2027 entry (national deadline 31 Oct).

26-30 Oct 2026 — Sheffield schools' autumn half term.

2 Nov 2026 — Extended deadline for schools to complete autumn census free school meals eligibility rechecks.

■ OFSTED & ACCOUNTABILITY: INTERIM EVALUATION FINDS INSPECTIONS LANDING BETTER, BUT WORKLOAD STILL A WORRY

▪ **Friday's independently-commissioned interim evaluation of Ofsted's renewed inspection framework found most inspected providers rate the experience positively so far.** IFF Research's interim findings, covering the first four survey waves since the new framework and report cards launched, found 88% of inspected providers agreed their inspection was conducted respectfully, 76% collaboratively and 78% empathetically, and 81% said their report card accurately described what it's like to be a pupil or learner there. Workload and wellbeing remain flagged as ongoing pressures, though most respondents said inspectors took steps to reduce stress on the day. (GOV.UK - Independent research finds Ofsted's new-look inspections are more collaborative and respectful, 9 October 2026)

→ **For your school:** *Useful to share with staff anxious about inspection day - the evidence suggests the new approach is landing better than the old single-word judgements, even if workload concerns haven't gone away.*

DATA POINT OF THE WEEK

88%

of providers said their Ofsted inspection under the new framework was conducted respectfully - though workload pressure remains a live concern.

IFF Research for Ofsted, interim findings published 9 October 2026

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. Explore School+

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.